

It seems that new heights have been scaled in ridiculousness. Says Michael Arrington of popular blog TechCrunch, "I think this is all complete nonsense. If Apple wants to go after the guy that made the Windows Mobile skin that looks like the iPhone, fine. But to bully bloggers who are simply reporting on this is another matter."

And you thought you needed to *buy* an Apple product to experience their award-winning entertainment skills.

EXTORTION

\$60 For A Crap-free PC

If you've ever bought your PC from an OEM, you've probably been subjected to all those "productivity tools" that they come loaded with—a disk optimiser here, a bandwidth meter there—all well intentioned nonsense to keep your computing experience happy. So common is the phenomenon that there's

You Have Lost The Lead...

This month was memorable for the amount of *Quake III Arena* that all of us at *Digit* played. Even the Test Centre (TC) guys, normally known to be snobs about their dual-GPU rigs, decided to partake in a little retro-gaming. Now anyone who's played *Quake III Arena* on a LAN with more than three players will testify to its addictiveness, and we were no exception.

The entire team waited for 6:30 PM, when all the big bosses went home and the fragging could begin. This madness was multiplied by the fact that Deepak, our Ed, was out of town for 10 days...

The *Digit* writers team began on a low key, this being the first time that we had rigs good enough to play an FPS game on, and were beaten mercilessly by

the MarComm and TC teams. We're better now, and at least offer *some* challenge!

DM17 has always been our map of choice, and Sanket the uncrowned king. It's always been almost pointless playing with him. However, his reign was brought to a screeching halt by Mayur, the newest addition to the TC. Apparently, sweet and quiet Mayur is everyone's worst nightmare in *QIII Arena*. All of us now know how much looks can deceive.

Deepak returned, heads rolled, *Quake* ended, work began, and we all had to spend late nights here making up for lost time. The beauty of it all is that none of us regret it, and are now all happily cherishing our withdrawal symptoms, waiting for his next trip abroad!


 DIGIT DIARY

even a special term for these tools—craplets.

So *why* are these on your PC, again? Turns out, the reason you're getting your PC for a reasonable price is that the OEMs make money off this crapware (that's the collective noun for all craplets, by the way). It's like advertising—if they can get their money from somewhere else, they might not let you believe you're being fleeced. However,

Microsoft has been complaining about this sorry state of affairs—after the Netscape vs. IE issue, they aren't allowed to dictate terms to OEMs, which leaves them sitting on their hands in the matter of crapware.

One of the topics raised with Michael Dell at CES was the issue of crapware, and how one was to avoid it. He asked all participants to name their price—how

much were they willing to pay for crap-free PCs? It was like an auction, and bidding ended at \$60 (Rs 2,800). That's Rs 2800 for crap we didn't want in the first place?

Note that no mention was made of actually being able to buy a crap-less PC. So if you're still going the OEM route, you should try the PC-De-crapifier (<http://www.yorkspace.com/pc-de-crapifier/>). ■

Blog WATCH

This month, popular topics for bloggers were FireFox 3, things to do in the new year and, of course, the iPhone. Here are prominent bloggers' takes on the three topics

Richard MacManus

<http://snipurl.com/feb001>
(http://www.readwriteweb.com/archives/firefox_3_plans.php)

Firefox 3 Plans and IE8 Speculation—Browsers Heading Apart Again

...While Firefox is still aiming for a broad mainstream audience, Mozilla recognizes that its strengths for normal users are its extensions and customization. It notes on the wiki that "Microsoft will continue to establish deeper ties from IE7/Vista to live.com & MSN" and even that other "web service providers" may introduce their own browsers (Yahoo? Amazon?). So Firefox is aiming to be the best general Web browser—e.g. it wants to be faster for AJAX apps.

Lorelle VanFossen

<http://snipurl.com/feb002>
(<http://lorelle.wordpress.com/2007/01/11/things-i-want-gone-from-the-web-in-2007/>)

Things I Want Gone from the Web in 2007

...Out-of-control Advertising
Web pages, specifically blogs, are now looking more like classified ad sections in the newspaper than

published works. They are ugly, cluttered, and some bloggers are giving up on some advertising techniques because of the "cheap look" and interference with content quality. Not every blogger needs to pay their rent with their blogs. Blog for the fun of it and let those who are serious about blogging as income make more money with lovely, interesting, and intelligently placed ads.

Jason D. O'Grady

<http://snipurl.com/feb004>
(<http://blogs.zdnet.com/Apple/?p=375>)

What may sink the iPhone

...There are a lot of issues with iPhone as others have deftly pointed out, not the least of which are the facts that it doesn't have a removable battery, it's locked to a carrier, it's wicked expensive (when you consider that Apple's getting a ~US\$100 kickback from Cingular on each unit sold) and the list goes on. But what may sink the iPhone is its lack of international roaming support...

...First, this phone will not work in Japan because it does not support the crucial international 3G band, known as 2100MHz WCDMA, or UMTS. Lack of 3G support also means less choices for roaming in Europe and other parts of Asia...